Lives, rights and choices: cards

Tuesday 12 January 2027 | P2 | 40 minutes | Year A

Humanities | LAUNCH | Spring 1 Week 2 | HUM-LAUNCH-S1-W02

Pink paper version. Read quietly, point, write, type, speak privately or direct a scribe. You may pass. No public answer or reading aloud is required.

These are teacher-written factual summaries. They are not archive extracts or testimony. No real person is quoted. S1–S6 form the class set; you do not need to read all of them alone.

S1 Lives before persecution

Europe before 1933; Amsterdam in the 1930s

Jewish people had families, jobs, beliefs, interests and hopes. Some followed religious traditions; others did not. They spoke many languages and lived in many countries. Jewish life was diverse and continues today. Anne Frank was born in Frankfurt in 1929. Her family moved to Amsterdam in the 1930s. There she learned Dutch, made friends and went to a local school. Her life was more than what later happened to her.

Anne is one person, not a picture of every Jewish life. Antisemitism already existed before Nazi rule.

Think: Name one part of a person’s life beyond persecution.

Research basis: H1, H2.

S2 Exclusion from state jobs

7 April 1933 | Germany

A Nazi law began to remove Jewish people from state jobs. At first, there were some exceptions. The policy treated people unfairly because they were Jewish. It could take away their work and income. Officials who wrote and carried out such rules helped make exclusion happen.

This was a choice made and enforced by people. It was not the fault of those targeted.

Think: What could losing a job change in a person’s life?

Research basis: H3.

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S3 Citizenship rights taken away

15 September 1935 and later rules | Germany

The Nuremberg Laws, followed by more rules, took away German Jews' citizenship rights. Jewish people lost political rights. Nazi rules used family ancestry to decide whom to target. The Nazi idea that Jews were a separate biological race was false. Jewish identity includes faith, culture, heritage and community.

A law can be unjust. A state's rule does not make persecution right.

Think: What is the difference between a law and a fair law?

Research basis: H3, H4.

S4 Excluded from public schools

November 1938 | Germany

Jewish pupils were barred from public schools. Access to education was cut back. This also broke links with classmates and teachers. Earlier restrictions had already harmed Jewish life. These cards show some steps in Germany, not every step across Europe. Dates and rules differed in other countries.

State decisions and the people enforcing them removed rights over time. Events were not inevitable.

Think: Name a right affected and one effect on daily life.

Research basis: H3.

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S5 Actions and inaction

Nazi rule, 1933–1945 | Germany and occupied Europe

Perpetrators planned or carried out persecution. For example, officials enforced rules that excluded Jewish people. Some witnesses did not help people who faced persecution. Historians may call them bystanders. Others gained from exclusion, for example by taking over jobs. Such actions could make them more involved in the harm.

People had different power, knowledge and risks. Roles could change. A short card cannot tell us every person’s reason. Responsibility was not equal.

Think: What did a person do or fail to do? What could that change?

Research basis: H5.

S6 Help in Amsterdam

1942–1944 | German-occupied Netherlands

Miep Gies was one of several people who helped eight Jewish people hiding in Amsterdam. They included Anne Frank and her family. Miep brought food and library books. The people in hiding also made choices to protect their lives. Helping could bring serious danger. Only a small minority helped rescue Jewish people.

The eight were arrested in August 1944. Anne died in 1945. Help mattered, but it could not guarantee survival. We remember Anne’s life as well as her death.

Think: What help did Miep give? Why should we avoid a simple happy ending?

Research basis: H2, H6, H7.